

So you're thinking about languages

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI.

General document translation came out at **8.8 out of 10** — the highest score of anything we measured anywhere.

Court and legal interpreting came out at **4.3**.

Same languages. Same training. A 4.5-point gap — the widest split inside any career we looked at.

So this isn't a question of whether languages are a career. It's a question of *which* one.

The 60-second version

- Document translation is the most exposed work in the entire index. That's settled.
 - Interpreting is genuinely protected — and pays \$350–\$1,200 a day at the specialist end.
 - One statistic explains everything:** 73% of companies use AI translation internally, only 19% for regulated work.
 - The survival condition isn't quality. It's **consequence**.
 - And fluency has stopped being the qualification. It's now the entry ticket.
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The statistic that explains the whole thing

Industry research found:

73% of enterprises use AI translation internally. Only 19% rely on it for external or regulated communication.

That's the map.

Internal documents, first drafts, understanding a foreign email, bulk content — automated completely, and it's not coming back.

External communication, regulated content, anything where an error has legal or medical consequences — still human, and increasingly so.

And here's why the split is so absolute

Look at what the two things cost:

	PRICE
Machine translation	\$10–\$20 per million characters — fractions of a cent per word
Human translation	\$0.08–\$0.50 per word
Specialist legal/medical translation	\$0.15–\$0.50 per word
Live interpreting	\$80–\$250 per hour
Conference interpreting	\$600–\$1,200 per day

That's a cost difference of a hundred to a thousand times. No amount of "but the human is better" survives that gap for routine content.

So what's left isn't the work that's done best. It's the work where someone has to be answerable for the result.

A mistranslated medication instruction. A contract clause. Court testimony. An immigration document. In those situations nobody is optimising for translation cost, because the downside is a misdiagnosis or a wrongful conviction.

The transferable idea: when something becomes nearly free to automate, ask what survives. What survives is the version where being wrong costs something.

Why interpreting is different from translation

People talk about these together. They're structurally different jobs.

Translation is text in, text out. Asynchronous. Reviewable. Correctable. Nobody's in the room. Every one of those makes it automatable — and those are properties of the *medium*, not of how hard it is.

Interpreting is a person, in a room, in real time.

You have to physically be there — in many legal and medical settings that's actually required by law.

There's no draft. You say the sentence and its consequences start immediately. No review, no second pass.

You're personally accountable. A certified court interpreter is answerable for accuracy in a way no system can be, and that certification attaches to you.

And you handle what the text doesn't contain — hesitation, tone, the witness who's frightened, the patient who's downplaying symptoms.

The scores

TRACK	SCORE
Court & legal interpreting	4.3
Medical & healthcare interpreting	4.6
Conference interpreting	5.0
Literary & creative translation	6.1
Localization & transcreation	6.9
Technical & specialist translation	7.6
General document translation	8.8

And note where this started. Document translation was already at 7.7 back in 2023 — before the current AI wave. This displacement didn't start with ChatGPT. It mostly finished during it.

Which makes translation the most mature example in our whole index — the closest thing we have to seeing where other professions end up.

What we won't soften

The generalist translation market has collapsed and it isn't coming back. Rates at the floor have hit \$0.05 a word. A career built on "I'm good at languages" has no economic foundation left.

Post-editing is now a big part of the market — checking and fixing machine output. It's real work. **It pays materially less than translation did.** Better to know that now than discover it at 24.

Most of this market is freelance, with everything that means: variable income, no benefits, and finding clients being a second job.

Where the money actually is

The protected end is genuinely well paid:

- **Court interpreting: \$350–\$750 per day**
- **Conference interpreting: \$600–\$1,200 per day**
- **Live interpreting: \$80–\$250 per hour**
- **Specialist translators (legal, medical, technical): \$60–\$150 per hour**

And here's the crucial trend: generalists face falling rates while specialists have held or increased theirs.

BLS projects around **6,900 new interpreter and translator openings a year** through 2034, with the strongest prospects in Portuguese, Mandarin, Korean, Arabic and Spanish — and **"particularly strong for interpreters who combine language fluency with domain expertise in law, medicine or technology."**

That sentence is basically your career strategy.

So what should you actually do

- 1. Aim at interpreting, not translation.** **That single choice is worth 4.5 points on our scale.**
- 2. Get certified.** Court interpreting and medical interpreting certifications are what turn language ability into protected work.
- 3. Pair your language with a real subject** — law, medicine, engineering. **The differentiator now is the domain, not the language.** The rate data proves it.
- 4. Target regulated sectors.** Healthcare, courts, government, immigration. Compliance rules around language access are *expanding*, and every one creates demand for an accountable human.

Does this actually sound like you?

The most important trait now: **do you love languages and something else?** Language alone has stopped being a career. Language plus law, medicine or engineering is a good one.

It also suits people who:

- Can **hold concentration under pressure** — interpreting is cognitively brutal in bursts
- Are comfortable with **accuracy that matters**, where an error has consequences
- Are **self-directed**, since most of the market is freelance
- Are genuinely interested in **people**, not just in text

Harder if you want salaried stability early, or if you're drawn mainly to written translation as a craft — that's the exposed end.

What actually matters when picking a course

- **Is there real interpreting training?** Not translation with an interpreting module — actual practice. It's a distinct skill trained differently.
 - **Does it support court or medical certification?**
 - **Can you pair the language with a substantive second subject?** Many language courses still don't make this easy.
 - **Does the curriculum deal honestly with machine translation and post-editing?** A course that ignores it is preparing you for a market that's gone.
 - **Where do graduates work at two years** — interpreting, specialist translation, post-editing, or outside languages entirely?
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Two things worth doing

Watch a court or medical interpreter work, if you can arrange it. It's a completely different job from what most people picture, and it'll tell you fast whether it appeals.

Then find someone working in languages and ask what share of their income comes from translation, interpreting and post-editing. The proportions will tell you more than any careers talk.

One last thing

Nothing here says loving languages is a mistake.

It says fluency has stopped being the qualification and become the entry ticket — and that being the person in the room, accountable, when two people absolutely have to understand each other, is work that isn't going anywhere.

Aim there deliberately. It's four and a half points better, and it pays considerably more.

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- [Interpreters and Translators — Occupational Outlook Handbook](#) — government data on openings and pay.
 - [American Translators Association](#) — the professional body and the certification landscape. Worth understanding before you choose a course.
 - [Translation rates in 2026](#) — the actual rate data, including the gap between generalists and specialists. Read it for the economics.
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There's a longer version behind this — full scores by track, how they were worked out, the economics in detail, what to ask a program, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.